

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Back Pain in Pregnancy

Understanding, managing, and relieving pregnancy-related back pain

WHAT IS IT & WHY IT HAPPENS

Back pain affects up to **70% of pregnant women**. As your uterus grows, your center of gravity shifts forward, placing increased strain on back muscles. Hormones like *relaxin* loosen ligaments and joints to prepare for delivery — but also reduce spinal stability.

WHO IS AT RISK

- Prior history of back pain or injury
- Multiple pregnancy (twins, triplets)
- Jobs requiring prolonged standing or lifting
- Weak core/abdominal muscles
- BMI >25 before pregnancy
- Second or subsequent pregnancies

SYMPTOMS & TYPES

- Lumbar pain — lower back ache, worse with activity
- Posterior pelvic pain — deep buttock/hip pain
- Sciatica — radiating pain down the leg
- Round ligament pain — sharp sides-of-belly pain
- Typically worse in second and third trimesters
- Often worse at end of day or after prolonged sitting

SAFE TREATMENTS

- ✓ Prenatal yoga and gentle stretching
- ✓ Warm (not hot) compresses — 20 min max
- ✓ Pregnancy support belt or belly band
- ✓ Physical therapy / chiropractic care
- ✓ Acetaminophen (Tylenol) **OTC**
- ✗ Ibuprofen / NSAIDs — avoid in pregnancy

POSTURE & ERGONOMICS

- Sleep on your left side with a pillow between knees
- Avoid high heels — wear supportive flat shoes
- Bend at the knees when lifting; avoid twisting
- Sit in chairs with good lumbar support
- Use a footrest to raise legs when seated
- Avoid standing for long periods without breaks

EXERCISE & STRENGTHENING

- Pelvic tilts — flatten low back against floor
- Cat-cow stretches on hands and knees
- Swimming or water aerobics — excellent low-impact
- Walking with proper posture — 20–30 min/day
- Kegel exercises to strengthen pelvic floor
- Prenatal Pilates with certified instructor

⚠ WHEN TO CALL YOUR DOCTOR IMMEDIATELY

- ⚠ Severe or sudden-onset back pain
- ⚠ Pain radiating down both legs
- ⚠ Loss of bladder or bowel control
- ⚠ Regular cramping or uterine tightening with back pain
- ⚠ Back pain with fever or chills (kidney infection?)
- ⚠ Numbness, tingling, or weakness in legs
- ⚠ Back pain with vaginal bleeding
- ⚠ Pain unrelieved by rest or Tylenol

♥ You've Got This!

Back pain in pregnancy is very common and almost always temporary — it typically resolves within a few months after delivery. Most women find relief with gentle exercise, good posture, and support. Your care team is here to help you stay comfortable throughout your pregnancy journey.